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Brand experience and brand implications in a multi-channel setting

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Branding scholars have been deeply engaged in the identification of different interactions between brand and consumer. Additionally with the evolution of the internet, increasing research has focused on which brand relationships translate to the on-line environment. The current research advances the examination of these relationship constructs in particular brand experience, brand identification, brand community, and behavioral loyalty through the simultaneous examination of the relationships in the off and on-line channels. To add clarity, the context of the study utilizes single-brand retailers to explore relationship dynamics, providing less brand noise than a multi-brand retailer. Our results demonstrate the effect of channel as a moderator among these brand and consumer relationships providing valuable insight into brand management in multi-channel settings. Additionally the benefits from the single-brand retailer setting are highlighted.

Keywords: brand experience; single-brand retailers; multi-channel; brand identity; brand community

Introduction

Branding scholars have developed a rich body of literature, especially over the past two decades, exploring the impact of brand with consumers. Examples include brand personality (Aaker 1997), love (Carroll and Ahuvia 2006), attachment (Thomson, MacInnis, and Park 2005), community (Schau, Muñiz, and Arnould 2009), experience (Brakus, Schmitt, and Zarantonello 2009), and service (Grace and O'Cass 2005; Brodie, Whittome, and Brush 2009; Thorbjornsen and Supphellen 2011), among others. The bulk of this literature is focused on the traditional marketing channels, including brick-and-mortar retail stores. Recently more attention has been given to brand concepts and the on-line channel, such as brand image (Carlson and O'Cass 2010; O'Cass and Grace 2008; Kwon and Lennon 2009b, 2009a). However, what is lacking in the literature is an understanding of the relationships between on-line and brick and mortar stores (which we refer to as off-line from here on) branding constructs. In terms of multi-channel retailers (i.e., those with off-line as well as on-line stores), consumers expect brand attributes in the off-line environment to extend to the on-line environment (Kwon and Lennon 2009a; Mitra and Fay 2010) and success depends on this consistency (Yoo 2011; Berman and Thelen 2004).

Since Brakus, Schmitt, and Zarantonello (2009) operationalized brand experience, there has been widespread interest in the construct from marketing scholars (e.g., their

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study has been cited nearly 300 times since its publication). Brand experience has been characterized as the sum of consumers' encounters with a brand (Chattopadhyay and Laborie 2005). In this study we propose that consumers' brand experience is antecedent to eventual brand loyalty, and test if this relationship holds across retail channels. We depart from Brakus, Schmitt, and Zarantonello (2009) by modeling the brand experience–loyalty relationship as mediated by brand identification and brand community. Brand identification serves as a foundation to brand personality which has been explored. However, important to multi-channel retailers is understanding the role of self-or social-identification with a brand has in the mediation relationship with brand loyalty. Further, we conduct two studies to test our hypotheses, and do so in the context of single-brand retailers. Single-brand retailers (e.g., Zara, Gap, etc.) as opposed to multi-brand retailers (e.g., Macy, Penney, etc.) provide a unique platform from which to study brand experience across channels. It is acknowledged by individual brands (e.g., Gucci, Prada, Nike, etc.) that controlling brand elements is more difficult and problematic when marketed through multi-brand formats (Dodes, R., and C. Passariello, 'Luxury Brands Stake Out New Department Store Turf', *Wall Street Journal*, May 4, 2011). Thus the control exerted over all dimensions of the brand which is afforded to single-brand retailers serves to greatly reduce the additional brand 'noise' associated with multiple brand environments.

We begin by presenting a theoretical framework for the brand experience–brand loyalty relationship, as mediated by brand identification and community. Then we provide a detailed discussion of the single-brand retailer context, clearly establishing these retailers as more suited for studying cross-channel brand constructs. We then test our research model in two separate studies: study 1 with single-brand retailers in the off-line environment and study 2 with those same retailers in the online environment. Finally, we consider the moderating effect of channel type by comparing a two-group model. We discuss the results in terms of scholarly and practitioner implications, further providing suggestions for additional research in this area.

Theoretical framework and hypothesis development

Brand experience

Brand experience is the sum of all product, shopping, service, and consumption experiences the consumer has when interacting with the brand (Brakus, Schmitt, and Zarantonello 2009; Chattopadhyay and Laborie 2005). Brakus, Schmitt, and Zarantonello (2009) operationalized a brand experience scale with four dimensions: sensory, emotional, behavioral, and intellectual. They describe brand experience as closely related to many brand constructs (e.g., involvement, personality, attachment) but distinct in its relation to consumers' experience with brand. Additionally, brand experience has a behavioral impact on consumers, affecting consumer satisfaction and loyalty (Brakus, Schmitt, and Zarantonello 2009).

Foundational to brand experience is brand itself. The literature has established that brands are part of a relationship between the consumer and products which are sold under that brand (Levy 1959). The symbolic representation of brand is distinct from other representations of brand, particularly its functional representation (Bhat and Reddy 1998). The symbolic nature of brand is an essential element for the establishment of a relationship between the brand and the consumer, which can develop into consumer identification with a brand (Donavan, Janda, and Suh 2006).

Branding is designed to elicit specific responses from consumers in an effort to develop a deeper relationship with consumers (Chaudhuri and Holbrook 2001). Successful

brands create tight bonds with their consumers, resulting in a form of competitive insulation from other brands. Brand experience is the initial step in the relationship between brand and consumer, ultimately determining consumer–brand interaction (Oliver 1997). Consistently positive brand experiences help the consumer form an identification with the brand both individually (self) and collectively (social), as well as develop a sense of community through the brand, product, company, and other consumers of the brand. The consumers' feeling of belonging, established in community, will ultimately lead the consumer to establish a sense of loyalty to the brand (Muniz and O'Guinn 2001).

The four dimensions of brand experience, operationalized by Brakus, Schmitt, and Zarantonello (2009), can be seen as aspects of attitudes and behaviors which connect the consumer to others through the consumers' sense of self (Escalas and Bettman 2005). The consumers' experiences with a single-brand retailer engage their sense of self from a behavioral, intellectual, sensory, and emotional perspective. Self-identification is not the result of passive acquiescence but rather a goal-oriented behavior for the individual (Schlenker, Britt, and Pennington 1996). Consumers utilize prior positive experiences associated with their desired self, to purposefully express their identity in social settings (Schlenker, Britt, and Pennington 1996). Consequently, a consumer's positive brand experiences will have a positive effect on their in-group affiliation, developing a self-identification with the brand. Therefore we propose that:

H1: Consumers positive brand experiences will have a positive impact on the consumers' self-identification with the brand.

Social-identification with a brand has been described as furthering an individual's affinity for a brand (Ashforth and Mael 1989). Under this conceptualization, the consumer aligns themself with others (in-group) through brand affiliation which best represents themselves in a social context (Ashforth and Mael 1989). Importantly, it has been noted that experiences with a brand which consumers identify as important, unique, and frequent are most likely to result in social-identification (Ahearne, Bhattacharya, and Gruen 2005). The unique element is particularly appropriate for the single-brand retail environment. Additionally, those elements reflect the behavioral, sensory, intellectual, and emotional aspects of brand experience. Consequently a consumer's positive brand experiences will have a positive effect on their in-group association, resulting in a social-identification with the brand. Therefore we propose that:

H2: Consumers positive brand experiences will have a positive impact on the consumers' in-group social-identification with the brand.

Brand identification

Many brand studies have focused on brand personality as a central construct in measuring connections between the brand and the consumer, including the seminal brand experience research (Batra, Lehmann, and Singh 1993; Diamantopoulos, Smith, and Grime 2005; Aaker 1997; Aaker, Benet-Martinez, and Garolera 2001; Brakus, Schmitt, and Zarantonello 2009). While this has provided many insights, brand personality is rooted in the identification literature (Kim, Han, and Park 2002). Within the literature on identification, a brand can come in two forms self- and social-identification (Ellemers, Spears, and Doosje 2002). Therefore in order to gain a deeper understanding of how identification impacts brand community and brand loyalty, both forms of identification (self and social) must be examined individually. A further examination of each construct follows.

Self-identity with the brand

In this study we model brand experience as an antecedent of consumer identification with the single-brand retailer. If all experiences are similar in direction, either positive or negative, the persistence of the attitude toward the brand intensifies. If those experiences are of a positive nature, the consumer may adopt the brand as representative of self. The most successful brands are consistent with, and reinforce, the self-brand image (Dolich 1969). Self-identification with a brand extends a consumer's self-identity to the consumer's possessions (Escalas and Bettman 2005). Possessions the consumer has identified with can be joined together under a common representative factor, such as brand. The representation of these possessions under a brand can serve as an external identifier of who the consumer is as a person (Belk 1988). Consumers place the highest importance of possession on those brands that integrate the consumers' self-image with their aspirational image (Escalas and Bettman 2005). Self-identification with the brand is based on congruent meaning between consumers and the brand, and is reflected in the shared social symbolism embodied in the brand, which is shared with the larger community (Escalas and Bettman 2005).

Attachment to possessions and the representative brand is an important symbolic representation of the beliefs and attitudes shared between consumer and brand. This is foundational to establishing self-identification with the brand (Hogg and Terry 2000). Further it has been noted that this identification can exist on multiple levels, such as with the brand, product, company, as well as other in-group consumers (Kuenzel and Halliday 2008). So a consumer can associate with Heinz (company), Heinz 57 (brand), ketchup (product), and those other consumers who use the same product. These elements associate directly with the elements of brand community (company, brand, product, and others) (Schau, Muñiz, and Arnould 2009). Therefore, we propose that:

H3: Positive self-identification with a brand will have a positive impact on developing a consumers association with a brand community

Social-identity with the Brand

While Escalas and Bettman (2005) describe self-identification of the brand, Hogg and Terry (2000) describe a social dimension of the association between consumers and brands. Brands that are prototypical representatives of consumers' attitudes and beliefs serve as symbols to others. These symbols indicate similarities in attributes, which are shared in common with others establishing an 'in-group.' Alternatively, symbols can be indicative of dissimilarities of attributes, which would represent an 'out-group' (Hogg and Terry 2000). Self-identification in today's society has moved from a consistent certainty to a constantly re-evaluating identity model (Elliott and Wattanasuwan 1998). The constant reassessment inserts uncertainty and instability into the self-concept, which can be countered through the stability found in the brand.

Social-identification, however, seeks to extend the consumers' identity with others of like values, while at the same time distinguishing themselves from others with differing values (Tajfel 1974). Social-identification increases consumers' self-enhancement by reducing uncertainty in the social environment. This is achieved via a social compact between similar consumers who share an understanding of brand attributes which engender affiliation with like consumers and disassociation from other consumers' who share in dissimilar brand attributes (Hogg and Terry 2000). These two points, self-enhancement and uncertainty reduction, are linked to the symbolic function that brand serves for the consumer. The brand signals to other consumers a shared social

attachment through a similar use of the brand (Hogg et al. 2004). In order to be enduring, brands create stable platforms representing consistent attributes and message themes which are repeated through brand experiences, reinforcing the brand-identification with the consumer. The stability provided by a brand serves to fill the uncertainty gap found in the changing social environment, generating consistency in the consumers' social-identity and allowing self-identity to adjust to changing stimuli (Elliott and Wattanasuwan 1998).

Consumers who establish social-identification with a single-brand retailer gain social stability from shared 'narratives' inherent in the brand message (Elliott and Wattanasuwan 1998). These 'narratives' reflect the attitudes and beliefs which are shared between the consumer and the company, products, brand, and other consumers. Therefore, consumers who have established a social-identification with a single-brand retailer share the necessary foundational attitudes and beliefs with the larger brand community. The relationship with the brand formed in social-identification across the many attributes associated with the company, brand, product, and others can also lead to a desire to connect beyond the mere social recognition to social interaction including repeat purchases and word-of-mouth (Kuenzel and Halliday 2008). Consequently, social-identification with a brand will have a positive effect on brand community. Therefore, we propose that:

H4: Positive social-identification with a brand will have a positive impact on developing the consumers' positive association with a brand community.

Brand community

Brand community further extends the concept of brand-identification in the form of action. Brand community moves the passive acknowledgement of social-identification with a brand to an active pursuit to join with others who identify publicly with the same brand, in an extended community (Schau, Muñiz, and Arnould 2009). Brand community from this standpoint can be viewed as a 'consumer centric' model, where the brand-identified individual interacts with the brand, other consumers of the brand, products of the brand, and the company itself (McAlexander, Schouten, and Koenig 2002).

The proliferation of community and networking websites in the online environment is an important and little understood vehicle for communication between consumers and brand (Fournier and Lee 2009). The ability to connect consumers in virtual 'communities' is becoming the focus of much of the communication on the internet (Kaufman-Scarborough and Lindquist 2002). As such, the internet is rapidly returning to its original premise which was for the sharing of information, social interaction, networking, and community (Reckseidler 2009). Traditional models for clubs or gatherings as modes of community are often time and geographically bound, whereas the internet offers a more immediate and flexible method of community (Ba 2001; Muniz and O'Guinn 2001). This allows brands to expand their relationship to consumers who may not have access geographically to interact with the brand.

Faced with the increase in the use of social networking and other forms of on-line communication, the concept of brand community and its impact on loyalty are becoming progressively more important as a phenomenon to understand. The brand attributes shared between consumers of a brand is one way to increase trust in an on-line environment, which can lead to strong brand attachments and loyalty in both the on-line and off-line retail channels (Ba 2001). Brand community is a significant relationship between brand and consumer and can, in a broader sense, represent a competitive advantage for the

company (Muniz and O'Guinn 2001). Brand community can also serve as a competitive buffer for the brand, reducing the need to rely on product differentiation as the defining element of competition (Muniz and O'Guinn 2001). Ideally, the result of the consumer brand community relationship is the competitive advantage of loyalty. Loyalty has been conceptualized as a single-dimension represented by repurchase behavior (Jacoby and Chestnut 1978). It has also been described as being two dimensional, adding positive attitude toward the brand to repurchase (Pritchard, Havitz, and Howard 1999), as well as three dimensional adding a cognitive dimension (De Ruyter, Wetzels, and Bloemer 1998). The holistic nature of brand community encompassing the consumers relationship with the company, brand, product and other consumers leads to intimate ties that exceed other forms of loyalty (Fournier 1998). Consequently, positive associations between the consumer and brand community will positively impact the multi-dimensional attributes (cognitive, affective, conative, and action) of behavioral loyalty. Therefore, we propose that:

H5: Positive consumer association with a brand community will positively impact the consumers' behavioral loyalty to the brand

Behavioral loyalty

Brand loyalty has been a considerable source of research and discussion since the early 1950s (Cunningham 1956). Brand loyalty can be measured by patronage intention, word of mouth, loyalty, and trust (Keller 2003). Since the earliest research, brand loyalty has focused on the level of loyalty 'proneness' and expression, or behavior (Ehrenberg 1959; Brown 1952; Cunningham 1956). While it is interesting to evaluate the degree to which a consumer may be prone to loyalty, it is essential to understand the behavior which results from loyalty. It is the behavioral loyalty which results in sales for both brands and retailers.

Brand loyalty has been conceived as a formative construct comprising six elements (Jacoby and Chestnut 1978). First, the consumers' actions must be non-random or biased toward an outcome. Second, there must be a behavioral response which can be measured in purchases. Third, those behavioral responses must be exhibited over time. Fourth, the solution set must relate with some consistency when engaged for a similarly defined purchase target. Fifth, the behavioral response from the decision must relate to one or more brand(s), relative to an acceptable solution set, and sixth the exhibited behavior must result from the engagement of an evaluative decision-making process. This definition sets in motion the dichotomous nature of brand loyalty. According to Yim and Kannan (1999), the first and most preferred form by marketers and retailers is exclusive brand loyalty. The second and less favored is divided brand loyalty. In the latter, the consumers' loyalty may be to a set of acceptable solutions, which may vary over time and situation (Yim and Kannan 1999).

Exclusive brand loyalty comprises the six necessary loyalty elements and highly predictable behavioral responses. This combination creates the very definition of behavioral loyalty. Behavioral loyalty is rooted in the prior purchase behavior and consumers' future intention to patronize a brand (De Wulf, Kristof, and Iacobucci 2001). By this definition behavioral loyalty is the most rigorous measurement of loyalty. This is due to the biased attitude toward the brand as well as the behavioral intention to maintain purchase continuity with the brand (Dick and Basu 1994). Because of the rigorous measurement threshold, behavioral loyalty has become the benchmark in marketing effectiveness, representing a successful integration of brand's marketing strategy into a relationship with consumers (Sharp and Sharp 1997). In order for this engagement to be

effective, behaviorally loyal consumers must also integrate their loyal attitudes across four dimensions: cognitive, affective, conative, and action (Oliver 1997). In the current research, the use of single-brand retailers minimizes noise, allowing the use of a rigorous variable to measure participants' loyalty across the dimensions noted by Oliver (1997).

Single-brand retailers

Brands generally are assets and sources of competitive advantage for both manufacturers and retailers (Barney 1991; Keller and Lehmann 2006; Runyan and Droge 2008). Brands provide consumers a physical representation of their brand statement through the products and/or experiences which they deliver to the marketplace. Brands are designed to distinguish products in the consumers' mind for the purpose of generating preference (Keller 1993). Most retailers provide an assortment of different manufacturers' brands and derive a large portion of their revenue from the sale of those brands (Ailawadi and Keller 2004), resulting in increased intra-format competition. As a further measure to counter intra-format brand competition, stores can elect to create their own brands (Ailawadi and Keller 2004). Single-brand retailers' strategy is to virtually eliminate intra-format brand competition by providing only their own proprietary brands for sale. This form of retail holds a unique position in the marketplace, as the retailer and their brands are synonymous (Jones and Kim 2011; Jones, Runyan, and Kim 2012).

Although single-brand retailers do not enjoy the two-tier marketing benefit of the multi-brand retailer (e.g., national advertising), they enjoy greater control of brand communication. Single-brand retailers must satisfy unique consumers, with differentiated messages linked to specific purposes. They need to do so while avoiding brand message conflict for consumers' who may have access to a variety of brand messages. Minimizing brand message conflict while reinforcing brand messages is essential for the single-brand retailer to drive brand enhancement and avoid brand dilution. Single-brand retailers (e.g., Abercrombie and Fitch, Victoria Secret, Banana Republic, and Starbucks) almost uniformly exploit a dense assemblage of brand cues in their off-line stores to differentiate themselves and better define the brand for their consumers. These layers of defined brand cues, including task and ambient lighting, custom fixturing, etc. in the off-line channel, are designed to enhance the brand experience and increase consumer interaction and spending with the single-brand retailer (Turley and Milliman 2000).

Study 1: off-line

Sampling and data collection

We utilized respondent-driven sampling (RDS) methodology (Gile and Handcock 2010; Salganik and Heckathorn 2004) to gain a sample which is comparable to the target customers of most single-brand retailers used in the current study (e.g., mostly female; 18–34; multi-channel shoppers). Initial respondents were college students from two large US universities, who received extra-credit points for participating. These respondents were then asked to give the survey to five friends or family members who fit the profile we provided (see above). This form of sampling (RDS) is a type of purposive sampling method, where the researcher knowingly sacrifices a measure of external validity in exchange for greater internal validity. Considering the extensive adaptation of existing scales, a focus on internal validity was appropriate (Churchill and Iacobucci 2009).

Due to this extensive scale adaptation, two separate pretests were conducted. First, we assessed the face validity of the measures by asking faculty and other subject matter experts

to critically evaluate the instrument (Churchill and Iacobucci 2009). Based on initial feedback, small revisions were made to the survey. Following this a pretest was conducted using 30 volunteers at the undergraduate, graduate and faculty levels to assess ease of use (Dillman 2007) and assess construct validity (Churchill and Iacobucci 2009). Once the pretesting was completed indicating that the survey items continued to measure the same constructs, the surveys were distributed using the RDS method. The final sample achieved a participant mix that was comparable to those targeted by the single-brand retailers used in this study. The demographic make-up of the sample can be seen in Table 1.

Measures

Participants were asked to select one retailer from a list of 43 single-brand retailers of men's and women's apparel, personal care, home goods, and food. Of these stores the top 10, Victoria Secret, J. Crew, American Eagle Outfitters, Gap, Eddie Bauer, Urban Outfitter, Anthropology, The Limited, Abercrombie and Fitch, and Hollister, account for over 70% of the selections made by participants. The entire list can be found in Table 2. Participants were instructed to respond to all survey questions based on their relationship to, and experiences with, the off-line physical store environment of the single-brand retailer selected. Several large branded-product manufacturers (e.g., Nike, Fossil, Lucky Brand) have widespread retail distribution in multi-brand retail stores as well as through proprietary brand stores. Therefore, to reduce participant confusion in responding to the survey, these proprietary brand stores were eliminated from the single-brand retailer list.

The measures for the balance of the survey are from previously operationalized scales. Scale items for *brand experience* are adapted from the brand experience scale (Brakus, Schmitt, and Zarantonello 2009). S*elf-identification with a brand* was adapted from the self-brand connection scale (Escalas and Bettman 2003). S*ocial-identification with a brand* was adapted from the identification with a psychological group (IDPG) (Mael and Tetrick 1992). Previous adaptations of this scale have shown robustness in consumer settings (Badrinarayanan and Laverie 2011; He, Li, and Harris 2012). Mael and Tetrick (1992) conceptualize IDPG as representative of sharing experiences or characteristics with important others in a group setting. The scale has revealed a significant relationship between group identification and community (Ma and Agarwal 2007), making it ideal for the current study which includes brand community. *Brand community* was adapted from the brand community scale (McAlexander, Schouten, and Koenig 2002), and *behavioral loyalty* was adapted from the behavioral loyalty scale (De Wulf, Kristof, and Iacobucci 2001). The brand experience, brand community, self-identification, and social-identification scale items were rated on a 7-point Likert scale. Behavioral loyalty is measured with continuous-level responses (i.e., 0–100% and 0–10) and a 7-point scale anchored by 'very rarely' to 'very frequently.' The survey concluded with a brief set of demographic questions.

When measurement variance can be attributed to method of measurement rather than the factors which the measures represent common method bias is said to be present (Podsakoff et al. 2003) and is potentially problematic. This issue was addressed *a priori* using different steps suggested by Podsakoff et al. (2003), focusing specifically on item context and item characteristics effects. These effects were the most likely method bias-causing in our study. To reduce item characteristic effects we paid close attention to the complexity of scale items and constructed our scale adaptations so that sentence structure was as simple and unambiguous as possible. Next, we used different scale formats and anchors, including Likert, frequency, and percentages, as well 7 point, 10 point, and continuous (0–100%) scales.

Table 1. Sample demographics.

Demographics					
Gender (%)	Marital (%)	Employment (%)	Ethnicity (%)	Age	Income (%)
Female 78	Single 79	Work 56	Caucasian 88	25 (Avg.) – standard deviation 11.315	$40,000–49,999
Male 22	Relationship 21	Student 43 Retired 1	African American 7 Asian 2 Hispanic 2 Other 1		

Table 2. Single-brand retailer selection.

Women's apparel		Men's apparel	Home/Food/Cosmetic
Abercrombie	J. Crew	Abercrombie	Pottery Barn
Abercrombie and Fitch	J. Jill	Abercrombie and Fitch	Restoration Hardware
Aerie	Lane Bryant	Aeropostale	Yankee Candle
Aeropostale	Limited Too	American Eagle Outfitter	Z. Gallerie
American Eagle Outfitter	NY&Co.	Brooks Brothers	Starbucks
Ann Taylor	Old Navy	Eddie Bauer	Pottery Barn
Ann Taylor Loft	PacSun	Express	The Body Shop
Anthropologie	Ruehl No. 925	Gap	
Benetton	Soma	Hollister	
Brooks Brothers	The Body Shop	J. Crew	
Cache	The Limited	Joseph A. Bank	
Chico's	Urban Outfitters	Old Navy	
Coldwater Creek	Victoria Secret	PacSun	
Eddie Bauer	White House/Black Market	Ruehl No. 925	
Express	77Kids	Urban Outfitters	
Gap	Hollister		

To reduce the chances of item context effects, we were careful to ensure that all items (especially in the beginning) were neutral in nature to avoid causing positive or negative mood induction. Further, to reduce item priming effects (Salancik 1984), measures of the dependent variable followed rather than preceded measures of the independent variables. We also utilized scales which were rather lengthy in nature, increasing the likelihood that answers to previous scales would not influence answers to current scales (Harrison, McLaughlin, and Coalter 1996). Finally, we did not inter-mix scale items, keeping them together as 'blocks' throughout. Podsakoff et al. (2003) note that this method is likely to reduce inter-construct correlations, thus also reducing the chance for common method bias. To assess the extent to which our efforts to reduce common method bias were successful, we employed Harman's one-factor test (Podsakoff and Organ 1986). No single, general factor was extracted, with nine factors emerging with Eigenvalues greater than one, and together explaining about 72% of the variance. We provide our research model in Figure 1 for the off-line retail environment.

Analysis of measures

Measurement model

We first address the two second-order factors of brand experience and brand community. Our first step was to assess the factor structure of these two factors in terms of their first-order factor, which was accomplished through confirmatory factor analysis (CFA). Each indicator loaded significantly on its designated factor, displaying convergent validity. We then employed a parceling strategy (Williams and O'Boyle 2008; Yuan, Bentler, and Kano 1997) for three reasons: to specify the most parsimonious model; reduce parameter to sample ratio; and to utilize the Brakus, Schmitt, and Zarantonello (2009) methodology. Both of these second-order factors are reflective, therefore parceling generates no fundamental change in the measurement or the function of the construct within the model

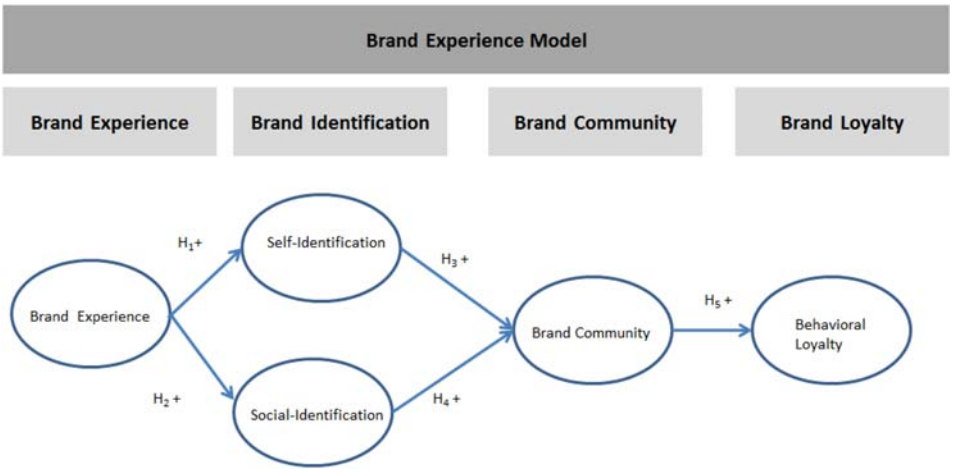

Figure 1. Research model.

(Yuan, Bentler, and Kano 1997). We then fit the full measurement model with all latent constructs included.

Confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) was employed using the maximum likelihood estimation in AMOS 18 to assess measurement model fit. Initial model fit was not satisfactory. From review of standardized residuals, there was significant multi-collinearity within both the self and social-identification measures. In an effort to minimize the collinearity, the number of indicators was reduced individually (i.e., not all at once) following established methodology (Bentler and Bonett 1980), using theoretical guidance. We reviewed prior empirical uses of the each scale and found most researchers utilized fewer items in subsequent hypothesis testing. Escalas and Bettman (2005) retained only three items from their self-identification scale (from the original seven) in final analyses. Mael and Tetrick's (1992) original ten-item scale has been used as a two-item construct (Lam et al. 2010), a three-item construct (Badrinarayanan and Laverie 2011; Mael and Tetrick 1992), and a five-item construct (He, Li, and Harris 2012). We feel confident that reducing the items in each scale, based on the extant literature, will not alter the empirical meaning of either construct. The result was a final self-identification construct containing four indicators and social-identification represented by three measurement items (see Table 3 for scale items retained).

The measurement model was then examined for fit using the following indices: χ^2 (95) = 219.226, $p < 0.000$; χ^2/df ratio = 2.308; comparative fit index (CFI) = 0.961; and root mean square error of approximation (RMSEA) = 0.060, thus exhibiting good fit. Factor loadings were all above 0.50, which establishes adequate loadings on designated factors (Fornell and Larcker 1981). The composite reliabilities ranged 0.921–0.971, indicating adequate internal consistency (Nunnally and Bernstein 1994). Each factor had an average variance extracted (AVE) greater than 0.50, and larger than the shared variance of all possible pairs of constructs (see Table 4), establishing convergent and discriminant validity (Fornell and Larcker 1981).

Structural model and hypotheses testing

A structural model was used to test hypothesized relationships among constructs. Goodness-of-fit statistics indicated the overall acceptability of the structural model,

Table 3. Scale items with composite reliability and factor loading.

Scale	Survey adjusted scale items	Study 1		Study 2	
		Composite reliability	Factor loadings	Composite reliability	Factor loadings
Brand experience	THIS STORE BRAND makes a strong impression on my visual sense or other senses.	0.971	0.318***	0.980	0.785***
	I find THIS STORE BRAND interesting in a sensory way.		0.8359***		0.838***
	THIS STORE BRAND induces feelings and sentiments.		0.854***		0.837***
	THIS STORE BRAND is an emotional brand.		0.768***		0.767***
	I engage in physical actions and behaviors when I use THIS STORE BRAND.		0.766***		0.784***
	THIS STORE BRAND results in bodily experiences		0.768***		0.737***
	I engage in a lot of thinking when I encounter THIS STORE BRAND.		0.684***		0.653***
	THIS STORE BRAND stimulates my curiosity.		0.393***		0.704***
	THIS STORE BRAND stimulates problem solving.		0.623***		0.527***
Self-brand connection	THIS STORE BRAND reflects who I am.	0.966	0.811***	0.964	0.822***
	I use THIS STORE BRAND to communicate who I am to other people.		0.750***		0.755***
	I think THIS STORE BRAND (could) help(s) me become the type of person I want to be.		0.653***		0.658***
	I consider THIS STORE BRAND to be 'me' (it reflects who I consider myself to be or the way that I want to present myself to others).		0.797***		0.808***
Social-brand connection	When someone criticizes THIS STORE BRAND, it feels like a personal insult.	0.948	0.836***	0.946	0.834***
	I'm very interested in what others think about THIS STORE BRAND.		0.646***		0.685***
	When someone praises THIS STORE BRAND, it feels like a personal compliment.		0.731***		0.729***
Brand community	I love my products from THIS STORE BRAND.	0.909	0.576***	0.980	0.653***
	I am proud of my products from THIS STORE BRAND.		0.715***		0.785***
	Products from THIS STORE BRAND are some of my favorite possessions.		0.733***		0.880***
	I would recommend THIS STORE BRAND to my friends		0.710**		0.586***
	Product from THIS STORE BRAND is of the highest quality.		0.598***		0.761***
	If I were to buy product that THIS STORE BRAND sells. I would buy it from THIS STORE BRAND.		0.758***		0.861***
	THIS STORE BRAND understands my needs.		0.536***		0.505***
	THIS STORE BRAND cares about my opinions.		0.763***		0.917***

	I have met wonderful people because of THIS STORE BRAND.		0.721***		0.460***
	I feel a sense of kinship with other people who own products of THIS STORE BRAND.		0.626***		0.793***
	I have an interest in a club or social network for people who own product of THIS STORE BRAND.		0.662***		0.662***
Behavioral loyalty'	How often do you purchase THIS PRODUCT from THIS STORE BRAND compared to brands at other stores?	0.921	0.789***	0.889	0.796***
	Of the 10 times you select a store to buy THIS PRODUCT at, how many times do you select THIS STORE BRAND?		0.805***		0.880***

Note: ***$p < 0.001$.

Table 4. Construct reliability and AVE study 1.

Factor	Composite reliability	1	2	3	4	5
Brand experience	0.965	0.937				
Self-identification with brand	0.966	0.683	0.937			
Social-identification with brand	0.948	0.760	0.861	0.928		
Brand community	0.966	0.830	0.751	0.833	0.958	
Behavioral loyalty	0.716	0.161	0.063	0.087	0.245	0.680

χ^2 (112) = 298.326, $p < 0.000$; χ^2/df ratio = 2.664; CFI = 0.944; and RMSEA = 0.068. The model illustrating the results of hypotheses testing can be found in Figure 2.

Results

All hypotheses were accepted. Hypothesis 1 is supported, as there is a significant relationship between brand experience and self-identification (H1, $\gamma = 0.846$, $p < 0.001$). Hypothesis 2 is also supported with a significant path from brand experience to social-identification (H2, $\gamma = 0.927$, $p < 0.001$). Hypothesis 3 is supported, indicating a significant relationship between self-identification and brand community (H3, $\gamma = 0.288$, $p < 0.001$). Hypothesis 4 is also supported with a significant relationship between social-identification with brand community (H4, $\gamma = 0.609$, $p < 0.001$). Finally, H5 is supported as there is a significant relationship between brand community and behavioral loyalty (H5, $\gamma = 0.210$, $p < 0.001$).

Study 2: on-line

Methodology

Data collection and sampling

The sample used in study 2 was derived from the participants who were engaged in study 1. Each of the participants in study 1 was given a unique identifier which allowed for the

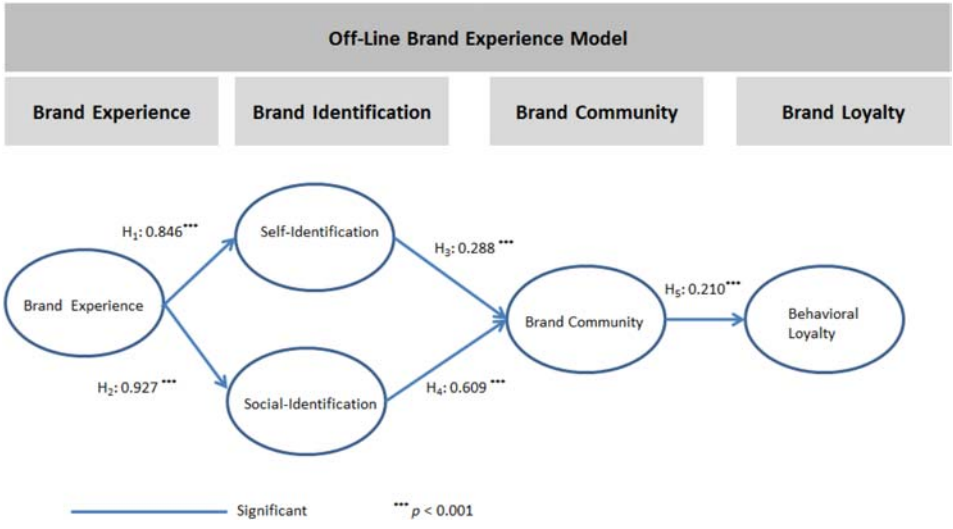

Figure 2. Study 1 structural model results.

tabulating of results to match participant responses from study 1 to study 2 (off and on-line). This same identifier allowed the participant to also be reminded of the store selected in study 1 as the source for survey responses. For study 2, participants received a survey instrument identical to that of study 1 with the exceptions of the change in verbiage from off-line to on-line and the demographic section was removed. Each participant was directed to respond to all survey questions based on their relationship to, and experiences with, *on-line* shopping for the *same* single-brand retailer they had selected in survey 1. The delivery of the second survey was conducted in the same manner as study 1. The second survey was delivered 1 week after the first survey, with the time differential intended to reduce any residual response memory from the first survey (Washburn and Plank 2002). The second study resulted in an initial sample totaling 268 participants. Nine surveys were considered to be missing significant data and discarded, leaving a final sample size of 259.

On-line experience

As retailers develop alternate sales channels (e.g., on-line), they are faced with managing the brand experience in divergent environments. Not all sales channels are conducive to the complex brand elements/cues single-brand retailer's leverage in the off-line channel. It has been shown that off-line retailer brand trust and the physical store service and branding elements significantly impact online shopping expectations and intentions (Jones and Kim 2011). Clarity of brand elements in the consumers' mind is a critical component in the development of brand equity, which is closely associated with brand loyalty (Chaudhuri and Holbrook 2001). Retailers unable to maintain consistency within brand elements across various channels, risk weakening overall brand image (Kwon and Lennon 2009a). Missing, altered, or added brand elements in a channel can fundamentally alter the consumers' brand experience. Single-brand retailers can closely monitor multi-channel brand experiences and may choose to mimic off-line experiential cues (e.g., color, ambient light level, and graphic styles) in an effort to minimize differences in the brand experience between channels. However, many single-brand retailers are forced to exclude one or more common off-line experiential elements (e.g., sound, personalized interaction, merchandise presentation, aroma, etc.), because of the inability to replicate the experience on-line. This creates variance in the brand message between the off- and on-line environments, fundamentally altering the brand experience for the consumer (Bergstrom 2000).

The complexity of managing the brand message, cues, and experience across multiple marketing and sales channels would seem to argue for focusing on a single channel approach (e.g., Amazon). Yet multi-channel consumers' spending habits exceed single-channel consumers by up to 30% (Demery 2009; Levy and Weitz 2012). Further, tech-savvy consumers leverage multiple technologies (e.g., computer, mobile, tablet) and communication channels (e.g., texting, e-mail, social media), resulting in increased spending and ability to influence other consumers to shop (O'Cass and Fenech 2003). The use of these multiple communication methods can increase consumer knowledge of the brand (O'Cass and Fenech 2003), consequently making congruence of brand messages even more vital.

Consumers' relationships to on-line brands can be considered an extension of their relationship with the off-line brand and therefore subject to the same expectations held by consumers (Kwon and Lennon 2009b). That is, consumers expect the off-line brand experience to be extended to the single-brand retailers' on-line environment. This remains

true even for those consumers whose preferred sales channel is on-line (Kwon and Lennon 2009a). Thus by definition, in order for the on-line environment to be successful and brand affirming, it must be representative of the off-line experience (Berman and Thelen 2004). For these reasons we expect the relationships between constructs in the model to be similar to those in the off-line study. Thus our hypotheses are the same as those in study 1 and we refer the reader to Figure 1.

Analysis of measures

Measurement model

Similar to study 1, CFA was employed, using the maximum likelihood estimation with AMOS 18, to assess the measurement model. Since one of our stated goals was to test our model across two retail channels, the scale items included in study 2 were identical to those used in study 1, to provide comparability. As with study 1, all items loaded significantly on their designated factors (Table 4). The measurement model was then examined for fit using the same indices as those in study 1: χ^2 (97) = 218.924, $p < 0.000$; χ^2/df ratio = 2.257; CFI = 0.952; and RMSEA = 0.070, which all fall within normal ranges of acceptance (Kline 2010). Factor loadings were all above 0.50, which establish adequate loading on each factor (Fornell and Larcker 1981). The composite reliabilities ranged from 0.889 to 0.980, indicating adequate internal consistency (Nunnally and Bernstein 1994). Each factor had an AVE greater than 0.50 and larger that the shared variance of all possible pairs of constructs (see Table 5), establishing convergent and discriminant validity (Fornell and Larcker 1981). As in study 1, we assessed common method bias using the Harman one-factor test (Podsakoff and Organ 1986), with no single, general factor emerging.

Structural model and hypotheses testing

A structural model was used to test hypothesized relationships among constructs. Goodness-of-fit statistics indicated the overall acceptability of the structural model, χ^2 (109) = 280.305, $p < 0.000$; χ^2/df ratio = 2.572; CFI = 0.933; and RMSEA = 0.078. The model illustrating the results of hypotheses testing can be found in the Figure 3.

Results

As with study 1, all hypotheses were accepted. Hypothesis 1 is supported, indicating a significant relationship between brand experience and self-identification (H1, $\gamma = 0.712$, $p < 0.001$). Hypothesis 2 is also supported as a significant relationship exists between

Table 5. Construct reliability and AVE study 2.

Factor	Composite reliability	1	2	3	4	5
Brand experience	0.980	0.931				
Self-identification with brand	0.964	0.615	0.910			
Social-identification with brand	0.946	0.855	0.837	0.924		
Brand community	0.980	0.804	0.763	0.827	0.958	
Behavioral loyalty	0.889	0.187	0.221	0.151	0.277	0.680

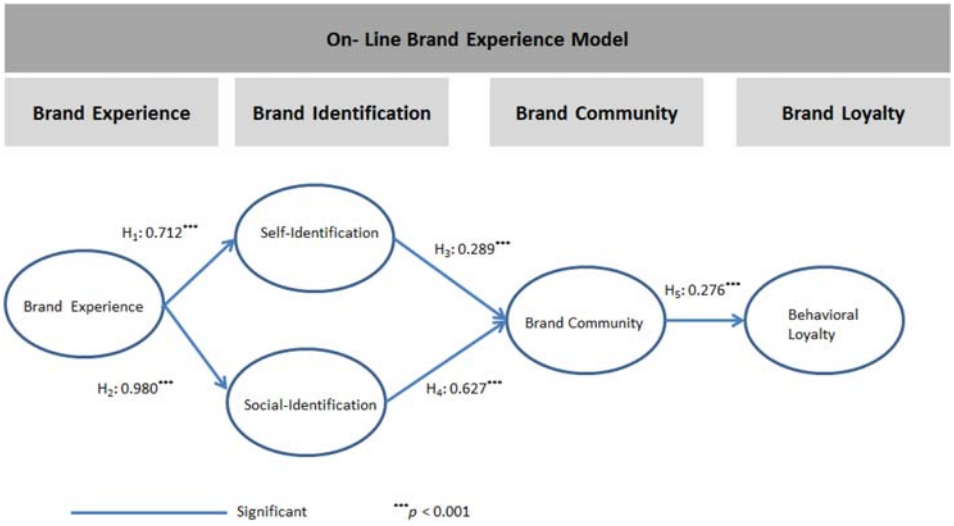

Figure 3. Study 2 structural model results.

brand experience and social-identification (H2, $\gamma = 0.980$, $p < 0.001$). Hypotheses 3 and 4 are supported with significant relationships found between self-identification and brand community (H3, $\gamma = 0.289$, $p < 0.001$) and between social-identification and brand community (H4, $\gamma = 0.627$, $p < 0.001$). Lastly, H5 is supported with a significant relationship between brand community and behavioral loyalty (H5, $\gamma = 0.276$, $p < 0.001$).

Post-hoc test for mediation and moderation

Research into brand experience has demonstrated this construct to be a significant predictor of loyalty (Brakus, Schmitt, and Zarantonello 2009; Chang and Chieng 2006). However, brand identification and community research have argued that they are important mediators in the consumer relationship leading to loyalty (Jang et al. 2008; He and Li 2011). The mediation of these variables between the brand experience and loyalty has been little tested. Some research has demonstrated that it is the interaction or experience with the brand which can influence identification with a brand (Rindfleisch, Burroughs, and Wong 2009). Additionally, when examining the nature of this mediation, there is research to suggest that brand identification is antecedent to community involvement (Algesheimer, Dholakia, and Herrmann 2005). Further, through brand identification a relationship can develop between consumer and brand which can strengthen the connection or loyalty to that brand (Rindfleisch, Burroughs, and Wong 2009). Finally, some research suggests that contrary to Brakus, Schmitt, and Zarantonello (2009) brand experience is only indirectly predictive of loyalty (Iglesias, Singh, and Batista-Foguet 2011).

Therefore, in order to further examine these relationships, we posit that brand identity is antecedent to brand community mediating the relationship between brand experience and brand community. We further posit that brand community is antecedent to brand loyalty mediating the relationship between brand identification and brand loyalty. As a result of these relationships, brand experience is not directly predictive of loyalty

but is only indirectly predictive through the mediation of brand identification and community.

To test this we conducted several χ^2 difference tests, using the full sample of on-line and off-line respondents. If differences were found in the larger sample, we could then test for differences based on channel type. We first fit a baseline model, specified as the formal research model (Figure 1). We then specified an additional path from brand experience to behavioral loyalty. The difference in χ^2 was not significant at $p < 0.05$. Again, using the baseline model, we then specified an additional path from brand experience to brand community. As with the previous mediation test, the difference in χ^2 was not significant. Thus we conclude that the best fit models brand experience's relationship to brand loyalty as fully mediated by brand identity and brand community.

While we propose that brand experience should be the same regardless of channel, based on retailer desire to create and maintain a uniform message to customers, we concede that this may not exist in practice. The relative immaturity of most retailer's on-line presence, as well as difficulties in replicating off-line strategies, may lead to inconsistent execution in the on-line channel. Therefore we test here whether channel type (for a single-brand retailer) moderates the relationship between brand identification and brand community. We expect these relationships may be different based on channel type for the following reason: first, results from studies one and two demonstrate that brand community is a good predictor of loyalty, confirming prior studies (McAlexander, Kim, and Roberts 2003). Brand experience was posited to be antecedent and significant in the development of brand identification (both self and social) which both studies confirm. The level of brand identification, however, will vary relative to the individual's perception of the execution of brand experience within each channel (MacInnis, Moorman, and Jaworski 1991). Further the brand experience by channel will also vary by the processing abilities and methods employed by individuals (Petty, Cacioppo, and Schumann 1983). Finally, if elements of brand experience vary by channel as described earlier, we likewise will see variation in involvement, thus impacting identification (Petty, Cacioppo, and Schumann 1983). Therefore, we examine the impact of channel on self- and social-identification.

We first fit a baseline model with data from both studies (i.e., all respondents to both off-line and on-line surveys). To do so we include only the 259 respondents who were the same across both studies. We then constrain the two-group models to be equal and assess the fit compared to the baseline. As seen in Table 6, the change in χ^2 is 68.837 (df = 48), which is significant at $p < 0.05$. The unconstrained model thus shows significantly better fit, providing support for further investigation. We then respecified the constrained model to allow the paths between brand identification (social- and self-identification) and brand community to be freely estimated. Table 6 shows the difference in χ^2 is significant, demonstrating the moderating effect of channel type. For social-identification, the effect size is large for both off-line ($\beta = 0.797$) and on-line channels ($\beta = 0.588$). However, for self-identification the effect size is small ($\beta = 0.262$) for the off-line channel, while it is moderate-to-large ($\beta = 0.493$) for the on-line channel. Thus, it can be concluded that

Table 6. Test for moderation by channel type.

Model	χ^2	DF	CFI	RMSEA	Change χ^2	DF	Sig.
Baseline	3309.702	1225	0.882	0.037			
Constrained	3378.539	1273	0.881	0.037	68.837	48	$p < 0.05$
ID free	3370.548	1271	0.882	0.037	7.991	2	$p < 0.05$

channel type (on- and off-line) moderates the relationship between brand identification and brand community for single-brand retailers.

Discussion

In the branding literature, brand experience is a new, though promising construct which has been shown to be distinct from many other branding conceptualizations (e.g., brand personality, brand love, etc.). Brakus, Schmitt, and Zarantonello (2009) found that brand experience (along with brand personality) is a significant predictor of customer satisfaction and loyalty. They rightly call for further research on the scale itself, which the current study undertakes. Like Brakus and his colleagues, we proposed a model where brand experience is antecedent to behavioral loyalty. However, unlike Brakus, Schmitt, and Zarantonello (2009) we did not model brand experience as having a direct effect on loyalty. Based on the brand identification and community research (He and Li 2011; Algesheimer, Dholakia, and Herrmann 2005; Iglesias, Singh, and Batista-Foguet 2011; Rindfleisch, Burroughs, and Wong 2009; Jang et al. 2008; He, Li, and Harris 2012), we test brand experience as only indirectly predictive of loyalty. We posit that brand community is also antecedent to behavioral loyalty and mediates the relationship between brand experience and behavioral loyalty. Further, we tested whether brand experience is a driver of brand identification (both self and social) and whether brand identification impacts brand community. We confirm recent research showing positive relationships between brand identification and brand community (Jones and Kim 2011; Yeh and Choi 2011), brand identity and brand loyalty (Kuenzel and Halliday 2010), and brand community and brand loyalty (Matzler et al. 2011). We break new empirical ground by testing the brand experience scale in a holistic manner, and examining these relationships in a comprehensive model, within a multi-channel setting. To that end we support the research of Iglesias, Singh, and Batista-Foguet (2011) which demonstrates that brand experience is part of the consumers loyalty relationship, but it is only indirectly predictive.

The literature has been mixed on the construct of brand identity (both self and social). Researchers have modeled the construct as a dependent variable (Escalas and Bettman 2005); partial mediator of community and/or loyalty (Kuenzel and Halliday 2010; Lam et al. 2010; Matzler et al. 2011); and as an independent predictor of community and/or loyalty (Jones and Kim 2011; Yeh and Choi 2011). Our findings extend the literature on brand identification in two ways. First by demonstrating the impact of brand experience upon identification, we introduce an antecedent to brand identification which had yet to be empirically tested. We clearly demonstrate that the strength of consumers' brand identification is driven by the strength and depth of their experience with the brand. This is an important finding, as brand identification has been posited to be a component of brand equity (Escalas and Bettman 2005). This finding addresses precisely the question Brakus, Schmitt, and Zarantonello (2009) posed as a focus for future brand experience research: namely, can brand experience help to build equity? Further, that the sum of the affective, behavioral, intellectual and sensory aspects of brand experience has a differential impact on both self- and social-identification with a brand.

Secondly, we provide the first comprehensive assessment of key brand elements in both off-line and on-line environments, simultaneously. Other scholars have examined various brand elements off-line only (Badrinarayanan and Laverie 2011; Kuenzel and Halliday 2010); on-line only (Madupu and Cooley 2010; Yeh and Choi 2011); or brands unconnected to any retailer (Lam et al. 2010; He, Li, and Harris 2012; Matzler et al. 2011). We stated initially that an understanding of these cross-channel relationships is lacking in

the literature. That is, few empirical studies appear in the extant literature addressing both channels, thus leaving a gap in the knowledge base. For retailers operating in both off and on-line channels, Berman and Thelen (2004) as well as Kwon and Lennon (2009a), states that brand elements should be consistent across channels, as customers expect such consistency. Additionally, many scholars point to the growing importance of the on-line channel in this mix (Duffy 2004). Yet other scholars have claimed that retailers operating in two channels should employ a strategy whereby brand differentiation is purposely large between the two (i.e., the retailer should differentiate the two channels as much as possible in terms of brand elements) (Yan 2010). Our findings clearly refute this position and support that of Kwon and Lennon (2009a).

The finding that channel is significant in moderating the relationship between brand experience, identification, and community, and loyalty further underscores the need to examine retailers simultaneously in both channels. Support for brand consistency across channels has been demonstrated in this research through the variation in brand identification response to the brand experience in each channel. The different response to the brand experience in the on-line channel as compared to the off-line channel can be attributed to missing, altered, or added brand elements which fundamentally altered the brand experience resulting in changes in brand identification.

However, most important is the identification that channel variation leads to differing responses in this case to brand identification between self- and social identification with the brand. Absent a simultaneous examination of channel effect, researchers may conclude that a single standardized marketing approach in support of a uniform brand experience would be beneficial. This research clearly demonstrates that approach would not be beneficial and could in fact be detrimental.

Research exploring identity in the on-line environment has described the anonymous nature of the channel as a source for identity exploration (Giang 2010; Turkle 1997). The ability to explore brand connections may absent the social stresses of the off-line channel and may allow the on-line consumer to establish a more fully realized self-identification with a brand. The establishment of new or enhanced identity in the on-line environment has had limited exploration in the literature (Griffin 2011). The on-line environment provides consumers opportunities which would not be possible in the off-line environment (Subrahmanyam and Šmahel 2011). Therefore, on-line consumers, who may lack the financial means or social skills to leverage social-identification with the brand, are more free to indulge in an on-line self-identification with the brand. This finding calls for both brands and retailers to develop on-line marketing strategies which are unique from the off-line strategy which can reinforce the self-identification with the brand.

Managerial implications

Traditionally retailers operated mostly within a single-channel, with few exceptions. Those exceptions tended to be mass merchants such as Sears, Roebuck, J.C. Penney, and Montgomery Ward, all of which sold goods through brick-and-mortar stores as well as comprehensive catalogs. With the advent of the internet and proliferation of e-commerce, single-channel retailers are now the exception, while multi-channel retailers are the norm. This reality means that most retailers have relatively little experience with managing brand elements across more than one channel. Our findings indicate that brand experience, identification, and community are as important to brand loyalty in the on-line environment as in the off-line. This is of particular importance to managers in formulating branding strategy.

Retailers operating in both the off- and on-line channels should be cautioned against strategizing for one channel and applying it (broadly) to the second one. Our research demonstrates that in multi-channel situations, most brand elements are equally important across both channels. The one exception is the relationship between self-identification with brand and brand community. We find that while the relationship between self-identification and brand community is significant for the off-line environment, the effect size is not very large. However in the online environment, this same relationship has a large effect size. Clearly, a retailer leveraging a marketing message driven by the off-line experience would be erroneous in assuming consumer self-identification with its brand and is not essential to the on-line customer. Therefore, retailers should understand the impact of channel messages supporting brand identification, both self and social. Doing so will allow retailers to leverage brand community to drive brand loyalty. Overall we show that brand experience, brand identity, and brand community all impact brand loyalty in a positive way. But as the findings show in terms of one key brand attribute, there is no standard way of doing business in a multi-channel setting.

Limitations and future research

The contributions of this article while significant are not without limitations. Although we believe utilizing single-brand retailers' reduced noise in the model constructs, our findings may not be generalizable to multi-brand retailers. Therefore examining how multiple brand messages impact retailers would be important. Additionally this research examined brand experience in a holistic manner. It cannot be said from this research if it was missing, altered or added brand elements, or channel message variation, or message conflict, which drove the difference in identification. Future research may wish to examine specific brand elements or messages for their impact on identification, community, and loyalty, to better ascertain what differences are most salient to identification reduction. Additionally, our measures reflected a relationship between the respondent and a brand and gave rise to significant multi-collinearity, in a few cases, resulting in the need to average some observed items. Further, respondents were not free to choose their own single-brand retailer unless it was within the list provided in the survey.

Future researchers may wish to investigate identification scales (self and social) in light of our findings as well as those of other researchers (e.g., Badrinarayanan and Laverie 2011; He and Li 2011; Lam et al. 2010; He, Li, and Harris 2012), which indicate that parsimony may be beneficial to research. The ability to optimize these scales with a minimum of scale items would not only reduce survey length but perhaps also collinearity as seen in this research.

Conclusion

Many brand scholars have put forth efforts to understand both off- and on-line branding. However the literature is lacking when examining the relationship dyad between a brand's efforts in both channels. In response to this need this study simultaneously measures the brand relationship in both the on- and off-line channels. Furthermore, this study introduces single-brand retailers as an optimal choice for studying changes in the brand relationship by channel. Single-brand retailers can exert significantly more control over brand elements and messaging. Additionally, this research adds to the body of knowledge on single-brand retailers which is also lacking in the extant literature. While this research makes a

significant contribution in several areas of brand research, it is hoped that this research will inspire more study into the off and on-line channel dyad.

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